

The Unsurpassed Surgery - Method of the Buddhas

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It may come as a surprise to many meditators to learn that the Buddha did not make use of meditation centers or meditation retreats to help his disciples attain the fruits of his teachings such as stream entry, once-returner, non-returner and arahantship. The Buddha is not found in the Suttas to say to his disciples, “These are meditation halls, these are meditation cells. Meditate, O bhikkhus, do not be negligent, lest you regret it later. This is our instruction to you.” Rather, he is found in the Suttas to say: “These are the foot of trees, O bhikkhus, these are empty huts. Meditate, O bhikkhus, do not be negligent, lest you regret it later. This is our instruction to you.”

Some have confused monasteries in the Buddha’s time such as the Jetavana Grove, Anathapindhika’s Park or the Mansion of Migara’s Mother to have been meditation centers. But these were the residence of the order of bhikkhus with an assembly hall for carrying out dhamma related functions, including ordinations, dhamma talks and dhamma discussions. As instructed by the Buddha, the bhikkhus and bhikkhunis would find roots of trees and empty huts in nearby forests and dwell there for their day’s meditation. They would then return to the monastery to hear dhamma talks or have dhamma discussions.

Not only are there no records in the Suttas of group meditation instructions from the Buddha, but silent meditation retreat without discussions on the dhamma among the participants is highly criticized by the Buddha in the *vinaya khandaka (mahāvagga 4, pavarana)* as follows:

Then the Auspicious One said this to those bhikkhus: “But in what way, O bhikkhus, did you, without disputing, united and happily together, spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not become weary on account of almsfood?”

Here, O Bhante, many of us bhikkhus, friends and associates, accepted a certain residence in the Kosalan country for the rains retreat. It occurred to us, O Bhante: “By what means might we, without disputing, united and happily together, spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not become weary on account of almsfood?”

Then it occurred to us, O Bhante: “If we neither speak nor converse with one another, the one who returns from village alms gathering first should set out the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, set out the drinking water and the rinsing water. The one who returns from village alms gathering last, if there is any food left over, may eat it if he so desires. If he does not desire, he should throw it away where there is little plant life or in water where there are no living beings. He should pack up the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, he should set in order the drinking water and the rinsing water, he should sweep up the refactory. Whoever sees the drinking water vessel, the rinsing water vessel or the toilet water vessel empty and void, should refill it. If it would not be possible for him, then having invited another with the wave of hands, they should fill it by joining hands together, but not on that account should they break into speech. In this way, without disputing, united and happily together, we will spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not become weary on account of almsfood?”

“So then, O Bhante, we neither spoke nor conversed with one another. The one who returned from village alms gathering first set out the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, set out the drinking water and the rinsing water. The one who returned from village alms gathering last, if there were any food left over, ate it if he so desired. If he did not desire, he threw it away where there was little plant life or in water where there were no living

beings. He packed up the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, he set in order the drinking water and the rinsing water, he swept up the refectory. Whoever saw the drinking water vessel, the rinsing water vessel or the toilet water vessel empty and void, refilled it. If it were not possible for him, then having invited another with the wave of hands, they filled it by joining hands together, but not on that account did they break into speech. It is in this way, O Bhante, that without disputing, united and happily together, we spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not become weary on account of almsfood?”

Then the Auspicious One addressed the bhikkhus: “Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having spent an uncomfortable [rains retreat], presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having lived together like beasts, presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having lived together like sheep, presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having lived together like enemies, presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. For how indeed, O bhikkhus, could these empty men, undertake the practice of followers of other standpoints, the observance of silence? This, O bhikkhus, neither [inspires] confidence in those with little confidence, nor increase the confidence of those with confidence. Rather, this only diminishes the confidence of those with little confidence and cause wavering in some of those with confidence.” Then the Auspicious One, having reprimanded those bhikkhus in various ways with Dhamma talk, addressed the bhikkhus: “The practice of followers of other standpoints, O bhikkhus, the observance of silence, is not to be undertaken. Whoever would undertake it incurs an offence of wrong-doing. I allow you, O bhikkhus, to invite the bhikkhus you live with during the rains retreat [for feedback] on three grounds, what is seen, heard or suspected. That for you will be a state suitable for communication, a state allowing for rehabilitation from offences, a state honoring the *vinaya*.”
–Vi Kd 4

So why didn't the Buddha adopt silent group meditation as a means of instructing his disciples as was commonly done by other teachers of the Buddha's time?

In this *vinaya* incidence, the Buddha explains that it is because "This, O bhikkhus, neither [inspires] confidence in those with little confidence, nor increase the confidence of those with confidence. Rather, this only diminishes the confidence of those with little confidence and cause wavering in some of those with confidence."

But in the *sangaṇikārāma sutta* (AN 6.68), the Buddha identifies delight in such group retreats as an impediment to making the breakthrough to the four noble truths as follows:

"Indeed, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhus who delight in company, who are delighted with company, who are devoted to delight in company, who delight in a group, who are delighted with a group, who are devoted to delight in a group, will find pleasure while alone in seclusion," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not delighting in seclusion while alone will grasp the sign of the mind," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not grasping the sign of the mind will fulfill right view," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not having fulfilled right view will fulfill right samadhi," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not having fulfilled right samadhi will abandon the fetters," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not having abandoned the fetters will realize nibbana," this possibility is not to be found.

"Indeed, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhus who do not delight in company, who are not delighted with company, who are not devoted to delight in company, who do not delight in a group, who are not delighted with a group, who are not devoted to delight in a group, will find pleasure while alone in seclusion," this possibility is to be found. "That one delighting in seclusion while alone will grasp the sign of the mind," this possibility is to be found. "That one grasping the sign of the mind will fulfill right view," this possibility is to be found. "That one having fulfilled right view will fulfill right samadhi," this possibility is to be found. "That one having fulfilled right samadhi will abandon the fetters,"

this possibility is to be found. “That one having abandoned the fetters will realize nibbana,” this possibility is to be found.

–AN 6.68

In the Suttas, the Buddha also compares the guided meditation that is currently popular at meditation retreats to how a blind person guides other blind persons as illustrated in the *tevijja sutta* (DN 13):

Thus apparently, O Vasettha, among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one brahmin who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher of teachers who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one in the seven generations of teachers who is able to see Brahma.

Apparently, even the ancient triple-knowledge brahmin seers, composers of the mantras, proclaimers of the mantras, this ancient mantra verses proclaimed and composed [by them], of which at present, the triple-knowledge brahmins chant, recite, rehearse, continuously repeating what was said, causing to pass down what has been recited, that is to say: Attaka, Vamaka, Vamadeva, Vessamitta, Yamataggi, Angirasa, Bharadvaja, Vasettha, Kassapa, Bhagu, even they do not speak thus: “We know thus, we see thus, how Brahma or when Brahma or where Brahma [appears].” Yet, those triple-knowledge brahmins certainly speak thus: “We teach the path to union with that which we do not know, to that which we do not see, this is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to liberation, which practicing accordingly, leads to union with Brahma.”

“So what do you think, O Vasettha, that being so, doesn’t the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar?”

“Certainly, O Bhante, that being so, the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar.”

Good Vasettha. Indeed O Vasettha, that those triple-knowledge

brahmins [could] teach a path to union with that which they do not know, that which they do not see, [claiming]: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to liberation, which practicing accordingly, leads to union with Brahma,” this possibility is not to be found. Just as, O Vasettha, a line of blind men go on in succession holding on to each other, the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. So too, O Vasettha, the statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins seem to me like a line of blind men; the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. These statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be mere speech, turn out to be mere words, turn out to be simply empty, turn out to be simply hollow.
–DN 13

The preferred method of the Buddhas is not to guide the blind but to cure the blind from their blindness so they can walk the path on their own without guidance. Thus, they describe the path they have awakened to as *cakkhukaraṇī*, maker of eyes, a teaching that gives vision. They also recite this joyous utterance when they awaken this Dhamma-eye as “the eye arose, knowledge arose, wisdom arose, noble knowledge arose, light arose,” as in the *dharmacakkappavattana sutta* (SN 56.11). What this eye sees is described in that *sutta* as follows:

imasamiñca pana veyyākaraṇasmim bhaññamāne āyasmato koṇḍaññaassa virajaṃ vītamalaṃ dhammacakkhuṃ udapādi: yaṃ kiñci samudayadhammaṃ sabbantaṃ nirodhadhammanti.

And while this explanation was being spoken, there arose in the venerable Kondanna the pure and spotless Dhamma-eye: “Whatever is liable to origination, all that is liable to cessation.”
–SN 56.11

The Buddha refers to himself in the *brahmana sutta* (IT 100) as the unsurpassed surgeon whose unsurpassed surgery gives this vision, which he describes as the Dhamma offering:

This indeed was said by the Auspicious One, said by the *Arahant*, as heard by me.

I, O bhikkhus, am a brahmin, ever devoted to [granting] requests, open handed, bearer of my last body, the unsurpassed doctor and surgeon. You are my own sons, born from my mouth, born from the Dhamma, created by the Dhamma, heirs to the Dhamma, not heirs in material things.

There are these two givings, O bhikkhus, the giving of material things and the giving of the Dhamma. Of these two givings, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the giving of the Dhamma.

There are these two sharings, O bhikkhus, the sharing of material things and the sharing of the Dhamma. Of these two sharings, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the sharing of the Dhamma.

There are these two assistances, O bhikkhus, the assistance with material things and the assistance with the Dhamma. Of these two assistances, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the assistance with the Dhamma.

There are these two offerings, O bhikkhus, the offering of material things and the offering of the Dhamma. Of these two offerings, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the offering of the Dhamma.

This is the meaning of what the Auspicious One said. Thus, this was said there:

The one free from miserliness who offered the
Dhamma offering,
the Tathagata, compassionate to all beings;
beings venerate the one who has crossed over
being,
that such-like one, best among devas and humans.

“This too is the meaning of what was said by the Auspicious One. Thus was heard by me.”

–IT 100

Those who acquire the Dhamma-eye and become cured from their

blindness are rightly called “children of the Buddha, born from his mouth, born of the Dhamma, created by the Dhamma, heirs to the Dhamma, not heirs in material things.” In other words, the Buddha’s method of guiding his disciples is to teach them the Dhamma in order for them to gain the *dhamma cakku* or Dhamma-eye so they can practice in accordance with the Dhamma themselves without needing to rely on anyone else, including the Buddha. The Buddha compares this method to a surgeon operating on the eye of a blind man to give him vision so he can walk on his own without being guided by others as described in the *māgandhiya sutta* (MN 75):

Just as, O Magandiya, a man blind from birth, who cannot see black or white forms, cannot see blue forms, cannot see yellow forms, cannot see red forms, cannot see crimson forms, cannot see the even and uneven, cannot see the stars, cannot see the moon and sun. He might hear one possessed of eyes saying: “Flawless indeed, sir, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean. He would walk in search of a white [cloth]. To him another man might cheat with a coarse robe stained with oil [saying]: Here for you good man, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean. He would accept it. Having accepted it, he would wrap himself with it. Having wrapped himself with it, contented, he would utter these words of contentment: “Flawless indeed, sir, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean.”

For him, his friends and colleagues, blood relations, might hire a physician, a surgeon. That physician or surgeon might make medicine: up-going purgatives, down-going purgatives, ointments, counter-ointments and nasal medicine. So owing to that medicine, his eyes would arise, his eyes would be purified.

For him, along with the arising of his eyes, his lustful desire in that coarse robe stained with oil gets abandoned, and he might also burn with unfriendliness towards that man. Rather, he might even burn with adversity thinking he should be deprived of life [thus:] Indeed for a long time sir, I have been cheated, deceived, tricked in this way by that man with a coarse robe stained with oil [saying:] Here for you good man, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean.

“It is just so, O Magandiya, even [if] I were to teach the Dhamma for you [thus]: “This is that freedom from diseases, this is that nibbana.” That you may know that freedom from diseases, you may see that nibbana. Along with the arising of the [dhamma] eye, your lustful desire for the five appropriable khandhas gets abandoned, and it will occur to you thus: Indeed for a long time sir, I have been cheated, deceived, tricked in this way by this mind. Indeed I only undertook form when undertaking, only undertook feeling when undertaking, only undertook perception when undertaking, only undertook sankharas when undertaking, only undertook consciousness when undertaking.

For me in dependence on undertaking, there is being; in dependence on being, there is birth; in dependence on birth, old age and death, sorrow, lamentation, physical suffering, mental suffering and despair arise. Just so, is the arising of this entire amassment of suffering.”

“I have confidence for the master Gotama thus, the venerable Gotama is able to teach me the dhamma in such a way that I might rise from my seat without blindness.”

Well then you, O Magandiya, should associate with true men. Since you, O Magandiya will associate with true men, therefore you, O Magandiya, will hear the true Dhamma. Since you, O Magandiya, will hear the true Dhamma, therefore you, O Magandiya, will practice the Dhamma in accordance with the Dhamma. Since you, O Magandiya, will practice the Dhamma in accordance with the Dhamma, therefore you, O Magandiya, will come to know just by yourself, come to see by yourself: These are diseases, tumors and darts. Here, diseases, tumors and darts cease without remainder.

For me from the cessation of undertaking, there is the cessation of being; from the cessation of being, there is the cessation of birth; from the cessation of birth, old age and death, sorrow, lamentation, physical suffering, mental suffering and despair cease. Just so, is the cessation of this entire stock of suffering.”

—MN 75

The key words in the Buddha's method is to teach the true Dhamma for his disciples to give rise to the Dhamma-eye for them to come to know just by themselves, to come to see just by themselves suffering and its cessation.

In the *mahātanhasankhāyika sutta* (MN 38), after questioning the bhikkhus on their ability to see *paṭiccasamuppāda* for themselves with the Dhamma-eye, the Buddha asks them:

Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you say:
“We respect the Teacher. It is just out of respect for the Teacher that we speak thus.”

Certainly not, Bhante.

Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you say:
“The *samaṇa* has said thus to us. We speak thus, on account of just what the *samaṇa* has said.”

Certainly not, Bhante.

“Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you acknowledge another Teacher?”

Certainly not, Bhante.

“Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you return to the practices, debates and auspicious ceremonies of common samanas and brahmanas, taking them as the essence?”

Certainly not, Bhante.

“Are you not, O bhikkhus, only saying that which you have known by yourselves, seen by yourselves, understood by yourselves?”

Yes, Bhante.

—MN 38

Nowadays many meditation masters claim to teach the path to nibbana as taught by the Buddha, similar to how the brahmins trained in the three vedas claimed to teach the path to union with *Brahmā*. But many of them teach based on interpretations of the Buddha's teachings that does not come from the Buddha. Some may say there is no need to worry because these elders are meditation masters who

teach the doctrine of the elders as handed down from teacher to pupil for many generations, but all one needs to do is to look at the very first sutta chanted at the First Council by the venerable Ananda called the *brahmajāla sutta* (DN 1), where the Buddha gives accounts of many meditation masters, some able to recall their past lives and some even able to attain the highest mundane meditative attainments like the domain of neither perception nor non-perception. The Buddha says in that *sutta* that his disciple who is a *sotāpanna*, like the leper Suppabuddha (Ud 5.3) has a knowledge that far surpasses all these meditation masters with such high meditative attainments.

The Buddha also reveals in the *thera sutta* (AN 5.88) that:

Endowed with five attributes, O bhikkhus, an elder bhikkhu is one who has entered upon the path for the non-welfare of many people, for the unhappiness of many people, for the non-benefit of many people, for the suffering of devas and humans. With which five?

“An elder is one of long standing, one long gone forth. He is well known, a celebrity of householders and those gone forth, one who has a retinue of many people. He is a gainer of robes, almsfood, lodgings, medicines and provisions that are necessities for the sick. He is well-learned, bearer of what he has heard, one who accumulates what he has heard, those dhammas which are auspicious in the beginning, auspicious in the middle, auspicious in the end, with the correct meaning and phrasing, proclaiming the life of purity that is utterly complete and pure, such dhammas he has heard much of, borne in mind, recited verbally, accumulated, and carefully considered mentally. He has not penetrated [those dhammas] by view, being one of wrong view and distorted vision.

Having turned away many people from the true Dhamma, he causes to establish [them] in the untrue Dhamma. Seeing, truly is he, an elder bhikkhu of long standing, one long gone forth, they set about imitating him. Seeing, truly is he, a well-known elder bhikkhu, a celebrity of householders and those gone forth, one who has a retinue of many people, they set about imitating him. Seeing, truly is he, an elder bhikkhu who is a gainer of robes, almsfood, lodgings, medicines and provisions that are necessities for

the sick, they set about imitating him. Seeing, truly is he, a well-learned elder bhikkhu, a bearer of what he has heard, one who accumulates what he has heard, they set about imitating him.

Endowed with these five attributes, O bhikkhus, an elder bhikkhu is one who has entered upon the path for the non-welfare of many people, for the unhappiness of many people, for the non-benefit of many people, for the suffering of devas and humans.”

–AN 5.88

So we see that even the well-learned and famous elder bhikkhus of the Buddha’s time who had not made the breakthrough to the four noble truths and did not even possess the straightened view of a faith follower or a dhamma follower, led their followers astray into what is not the true Dhamma, so what to speak about the venerable sayadaws, the venerable mahatheras, the venerable ajahns and the good lay meditation masters of later generations whose meditation techniques have become famous and garnered many followings?

Some may object that the reason the Buddha criticized these highly attained meditation masters in the *brahmajālā sutta* or highly learned elders in the *thera sutta* is that they did not practice *vipassana* meditation. But what is the *vipassana* that was discovered by the Buddha? Can modern meditation masters really teach their students to become endowed with the *vipassana* as taught by the Buddha?

The *pāli* word, “*passana*” or more commonly “*dassana*” is “vision”, and the “vi” prefix conveys distinct or penetrative. So *vipassana* is distinct vision or penetrative vision. But what is it a vision of? The Buddha defines it as the vision of dhammas in the *samādhi sutta* (AN 4.94) as, *adhipaññadhammavipassanaya*, which means, the distinct vision of dhammas with supreme wisdom (a *sekha*’s wisdom). The Buddha says in the *mahāsalāyatanika sutta* (MN 149) that both *samatha* and *vipassana* have to be brought into being (*bhāvetabbā*) with supreme knowledge (*abhiññā*), which from the *mūlapariyāya sutta* (MN 1), is defined as a *sekha*’s knowledge. *Adhipañña* is also defined as a *sekha*’s wisdom in the *sekha sutta* (AN 3.85):

Then a certain bhikkhu visited with the Auspicious One.
Upon arrival, having bowed down to the Auspicious One,

he sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One: “A *sekha*, a *sekha*”, O Bhante, it is said. “To what extent, O Bhante, is one a *sekha*?”

“He trains,” O bhikkhu, therefore, he is called “a *sekha*.” And what does he train in? He trains in the higher virtue. He also trains in the higher states of mind. He also trains in the higher wisdom. “He trains,” O bhikkhu, therefore, he is called “a *sekha*.”

“For the *sekha* in training,
following along the straight path;
First comes the knowledge in extinction,
From that immediately there is final knowledge.

From that final-knowledge liberation,
indeed knowledge arises for the such-like one;
“unshakeable is my liberation,”
the fetter of being is extincted.”
—AN 3.85

To help clarify what *vipassana* is, the Buddha advises the bhikkhu seeking the endowment of *vipassana* to ask another bhikkhu who is endowed with *vipassana* the following questions in the *samādhī sutta* (AN 4.94):

- (1) How, O friend, should sankharas be seen (*daṭṭhabbā*)?
- (2) How should sankharas be touched (*sammasitabbā*)?
- (3) How should sankharas be seen distinctly (*vipassitabbā*)?

Now how the seeing of sankharas or the distinct seeing of sankharas are only possible for the *sekha* is explained in the *samudayadhamma sutta* (SN 22.126):

Then a certain bhikkhu visited with the Auspicious One. Upon arrival, he bowed down to the Auspicious One and sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, that

bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One: “Ignorance, ignorance” O Bhante, it is said. What, O Bhante, is ignorance? To what extent is one entrenched in ignorance?

“Here O Bhikkhu, the Dhamma-deaf *puthujjana* does not wisely understand as it has come to be: “form is of a nature to arise as form is of a nature to arise.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be: “form is of a nature to vanish as form is of a nature to vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be: “form is of a nature to arise and vanish as form is of a nature to arise and vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be: “feeling..., perception..., sankharas..., consciousness is of a nature to arise as consciousness is of a nature to arise.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be: “consciousness is of a nature to vanish as consciousness is of a nature to vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be: “consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish as consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish.” This, O Bhikkhu, is called ignorance. It is to this extent that one is entrenched in ignorance.”

When thus was said, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One. “Noble knowledge, noble knowledge,” O Bhante, it is said. What, O Bhante, is noble knowledge? To what extent is one well settled in noble knowledge?

“Here O Bhikkhu, the Dhamma-hearer, the noble disciple, wisely understands as it has come to be: “form is of a nature to arise as form is of a nature to arise.” He wisely understands as it has come to be: “form is of a nature to vanish as form is of a nature to vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be: “form is of a nature to arise and vanish as form is of a nature to arise and vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be: feeling..., perception..., sankharas..., “consciousness is of a nature to arise as consciousness is of a nature to arise.” He wisely understands as it has come to be: “consciousness is of a nature to vanish as consciousness is of a nature to vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be: “consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish as consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish.” This, O Bhikkhu, is called noble knowledge. It is to this extent that one is well settled in noble knowledge.”

–SN 22.126

As for how the touching of sankharas is only possible for one who have distinctive knowledge of the deathless, the *sekha*, is explained in the following dhammapada verse:

yato yato sammasati,
khandhānaṃ udayabbayaṃ;
labhatī pītipāmojjaṃ,
amataṃ taṃ vijānataṃ.

From just the time he touches,
the arising and vanishing of the khandhas;
he attains joy and happiness,
that is his distinctive knowledge of the deathless.
–Dhp 374

Note that jānāto passato is knowing and seeing as vijānāto vipas-sato is distinctive knowing and distinctive seeing. So *vipassana* is a wisdom faculty that the *sekha* is endowed with, with which he/she sees the impermanent nature of all sankharas distinctly, with unmistakable clarity. It is not a meditation technique.

Now many *vipassana* meditation masters claim that the breakthrough to the four noble truths is not necessary to be endowed with this distinct vision of the dhamma that the Buddha calls *vipassana*. Their traditions have taught them that contrary to what the Buddha says about *vipassana* in the Suttas, *vipassana* is a technique that can be learned by experiencing impermanence through the senses. They teach that if one can experience impermanence in any of the six sense doors and just observe that experience or just make a mental note of that experience, then that is *vipassana* according to what has been passed down from a long line of teachers in their traditions. So here again it is important to clarify the type of impermanence experience that the Buddha taught as a path of purification.

The Buddha's teachings on impermanence can be divided into two categories, one which involves time (*kālika*) and one which is visible here and now (*sandiṭṭhika*), not involving time (*akālika*), inviting eye witness (*ehi-passiko*), leading onwards (*opaneyyiko*), to be personally experienced by the wise (*paccattaṃ veditabbo viññūhi*).

Examples of teachings on impermanence which involves time include suttas like the *āneñja sutta* (AN 3.116) where the Buddha gives an example of the impermanence of the life span of beings in the formless realms with the frequency on the order of tens of thousands of aeons; suttas like the *sattasurīya sutta* (AN 7.66) where the Buddha gives an example of the impermanence of the world cycle with the frequency on the order of an aeon; suttas like the *mahāsudassana sutta* (DN 17) where the Buddha gives an example of the impermanence of a universal monarch with the frequency on the order of hundreds of thousands of years; or the *assutavā sutta* (SN 12.61), where the Buddha gives both an example of the impermanence of the body with the frequency on the order of about 100 years and an example of the impermanence of the mind with the frequency on the order of hours. Now there are even some *vipassana* meditation masters who claim that one can observe the impermanence of the mind or the body with a frequency on the order of millionth of a second, where within one second they can observe the mind or body arising and vanishing millions of times. But no matter how small a fraction of a second one can observe impermanence, it still involves time (*kālika*). This type of experiencing of impermanence that involves time can be easily seen and understood by anyone, including puthujjanas, as the Buddha points out in the *assutavā sutta*. It is not the type of seeing of impermanence that leads to purification.

The Buddha teaches this type of impermanence to let us know that no matter what time scales characterize the impermanence of these activities, whether extremely short like a millionth of a second, or extremely long like tens of thousands of aeons, they are all simply reckoned as unreliable, impermanent activities, which are called *sankhārā* in *pāli*. As he tells the venerable Ānanda at the end of the *mahāsudassana sutta* (DN 17), they are teachings that should motivate us to make the breakthrough to the four noble truths in order to acquire the Dhamma-eye that sees where all these sankharas cease without remainder, so we can train ourselves to be liberated from them:

See O Ānanda, all those sankharas have passed, ceased, degenerated. Thus is the impermanence, O Ānanda, of sankharas. Thus is the non-lasting, O Ānanda, of sankharas. Thus is the unreliability, O Ānanda, of sankharas. With regard to all sankharas, O Ānanda, just this much is enough to attenuate them, enough to fade them away, enough to

be liberated from them.
–DN 17

The Buddha’s teachings on the seeing of impermanence that leads to purification is summarized in the following dhammapada verse (279):

sabbe saṅkhārā aniccā’ti,
yadā paññāya passati;
atha nibbindati dukkhe,
esa maggo visuddhiyā.

All sankharas are impermanent,
when one sees this with wisdom,
one attenuates suffering.
This is the path of purification.
–Dhp 279

This seeing of impermanence that leads to purification is bearing eye witness to the attenuation (*nibbidha*), the fading away (*virāgā*) and the cessation (*nirodhā*) of the very activities of impermanence (*saṅkhārā*). In other words, it is seeing the impermanent nature of the very activity of impermanence itself. It is enabled by arousing the pure and spotless Dhamma-eye that sees: “Whatever is liable to origination, all that is liable to cessation” as explained in the *dhammacakkappavattana sutta* (SN 56.11). It is seeing the stilling of all activities involving time (*sabbasaṅkhārasamatho*), no matter how long or short the frequency of that activity is. It is also called “seeing *paṭīccasamuppāda*”, “seeing the four noble truths”, “seeing the Dhamma” and “seeing the Buddha”. Since this seeing is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise, one does not have to wait for what is born to grow old, die and degenerate in order to see its disappearance; one does not have to wait for a so-called mind-moment in a millionth of a second in order to see the disappearance of the body or the mind; one who has aroused the Dhamma-eye has simply put an end to contact (*phassa*) to bear witness to the cessation of the very activity of impermanence itself. This is concisely summarized by the Buddha in the following verse concluding the *mahāsudassana sutta* (DN 17):

anicca vata sankhāra,
uppada vata dhammino;
uppajjitva nirujjhanti,
tesam vupasamo sukho.

Indeed, impermanent are sankharas,
arising and vanishing is their nature;
having arisen, they cease,
Their stilling is happiness.
–DN 17

So it is the experience of seeing the stilling of the arising and the vanishing activities of sankharas that is the path of purification.

In the *mahātanhasankhāyika sutta* (MN 38), after questioning the bhikkhus on this kind of vision that sees *paṭiccasamuppāda*, the impermanence of all impermanent activities, the Buddha states:

Good, O bhikkhus. So you have been guided by me, O bhikkhus, with this Dhamma which is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise. For that which was said thus, O bhikkhus: “This Dhamma is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onward, to be personally experienced by the wise”, it was with reference to this that it was said.
–MN 38

So the breakthrough to the four noble truths is required to gain the Dhamma-eye necessary to see the impermanence of all impermanent activities. The problem with not first acquiring the Dhamma-eye to personally be an eye witness to the Dhamma for oneself is that one becomes gullible to believe modern day meditation masters when they tell one that their technique is a path of purification, and so just like the blind man who wears dirty and soiled garments thinking he is wearing clean white cloth in the *māgandiya sutta*, one is not able to know and see for oneself that one has entered the path to purification, but need to take it on faith in the meditation master.

Thus, unless one is at least a *sotāpanna* (minimum requirement for a *sekha*), one can think one is practicing *vipassana* all one wants

but the fact of the matter is that one simply does not possess the Dhamma-eye by which one can distinguish what is *vipassana* from what is simply a misinterpretation of the Suttas by one's meditation masters.

A pre-requisite for the arising of the Dhamma-eye is the very starting point of wholesome dhammas, which the Buddha defines in the *bhikkhu sutta* (SN 47.3) as follows:

“Therefore, O bhikkhu, you should purify the very starting point of wholesome dhammas. And what is the starting point of wholesome dhammas? Virtue that is well purified and view that is straight.

–SN 47.3

The straightened view comes from learning the Dhamma through the proper explanations given in the Suttas and not relying on other interpretations of the Dhamma. As stated in the *māgandiya sutta*, association with true persons (*sappurisa*) or noble friends (*kalyāṇamittā*) in order to hear the true Dhamma (*saddhamma*) and practice in accordance with the true Dhamma is the starting point of wholesome dhammas in the Buddha's teaching.

Although the Buddha's teachings are widely available and easily accessible in many languages nowadays, the Buddha says in the *appamāda sutta* (SN 3.18) that the Dhamma is well proclaimed by him only for the one who has *kalyāṇamitta* and not the one without *kalyāṇamitta*. In fact he says the whole of the life of purity depends on a *kalyāṇamitta*, using himself as an example of a *kalyāṇamitta*.

In the *dīghajāṇu sutta* (AN 8.54), the Buddha defines *kalyāṇamitta* and describes the practice of virtue purification and view straightening as follows:

And what, O Vyagghapajja, is noble friendship? Here, O Vyagghapajja, whatever village or town a clansman lives, he associates with heads of household or sons of heads of household there, whether young but fulfilled in virtue, or old but fulfilled in virtue, those accomplished in faith, virtuous behavior, generosity, and wisdom. He converses

with them and engages in discussions with them. Insofar as they are accomplished in faith, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in faith; insofar as they are accomplished in virtuous behavior, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in virtuous behavior; insofar as they are accomplished in generosity, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in generosity; insofar as they are accomplished in wisdom, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in wisdom. This, O Vyagghapajja, is called noble friendship.
–AN 8.54

And so the practice of virtue purification consists of one discussing virtue with those accomplished in virtue and emulating them with respect to their virtue accordingly until one's virtue conforms to theirs. Likewise, the practice of view straightening consists of one discussing faith, generosity and wisdom with those accomplished in faith, generosity and wisdom and emulating them with respect to their faith, generosity and wisdom accordingly until one's faith, generosity and wisdom conform to theirs.

Unfortunately, nowadays, the word *kalyāṇamitta* has become current among disciples who stand in the faction of a *puthujjana*. Any dhamma friend who inspires one to practice is looked upon as a *kalyāṇamitta*, since the *puthujjana* cannot distinguish what is proper practice from misguided practice or what is the well-proclaimed Dhamma from counterfeit interpretations of the Dhamma.

But as the Buddha clarifies in the *sallekha sutta* (MN 8) with the famous simile of one sinking in the mud, he explains that it is not possible for one sinking in the mud to help another who is sinking in the mud. Likewise in his teachings, it is not possible that one who is himself untamed, undisciplined, not attained *nibbāna*, can tame another, discipline another, or help another to attain *nibbāna*; but it is possible that one who is himself tamed, disciplined, attained *nibbāna*, can tame another, discipline another, and help another to attain *nibbāna*.

In the *bahujanahita sutta* (IT 84), the Buddha singles out three types of persons as *kalyāṇamitta* or *sappurisa* who arise in the world for the welfare of many, for the happiness of many, out of compassion for the world, for the good, welfare, and happiness of devas and

humans. They are a Buddha, an *arahant* and a *sekha*. Only these three types of persons have arrived at the true Dhamma (*saddhamma*) and can distinguish the true Dhamma from the counterfeit dhamma (*patirupaka dhamma*). They are the only ones who are capable of explaining the well-proclaimed Dhamma that is auspicious in the beginning, auspicious in the middle, auspicious in the end, with the correct meaning and phrasing, proclaiming the life of purity that is utterly complete and pure. They have pulled themselves out of the mud and stand on firm ground unsullied by the mud. It is only they who understand the difficulties and subtleties involved in getting out of the mud and can therefore guide others out of the mud.

Given that nowadays true *kalyāṇamittas* are very rare, if one does not have access to a true *kalyāṇamitta*, then one needs to rely only on the Teacher that the Buddha personally appointed just before his passing away, which is the Dhamma and Vinaya as instructed in the *mahāparinibbāna sutta* (DN 16):

Then the Auspicious One addressed the venerable Ānanda:
“It could be, O Ānanda, that it occurs to some of you thus:
“The Teacher’s proclamations have ended, now we no longer have a Teacher.” But it should not be seen that way, O Ānanda. Whatever Dhamma and Vinaya has been taught and made known by me, that, O Ānanda is your Teacher after my passing away.”
–DN 16

Without a true *kalyāṇamitta* to readily provide the correct interpretations of the Dhamma, the task of view straightening becomes a lot more difficult but not unsurmountable. The task is to rely on studying the virtues and views of the noble ones only as taught by the Buddha in the Dhamma and Vinaya, and practicing accordingly with vigilance to emulate them until one’s own virtue and view come in conformity with that of the noble ones.

The following collection of Dhamma and Vinaya resources based on the accounts of the First Council known as “Vinaya Chanting of the Five Hundred” (*vinayasangīti pañcasatikā*) as recorded in the *vinaya khandaka* (*cūlavagga* 11, *pañcasatika*) are the only trustworthy guides for virtue purification and view straightening:

Dhamma:

- *Dīghanikāya*
- *Majjhimanikāya*
- *Samyuttanikāya*
- *Aṅguttaranikāya*
- *Suttanipāta*
- *Dhammapada verses*
- *Udāna*
- *Itivuttaka*
- *Theragāthā*
- *Therīgāthā*
- *Jātaka verses*

Vinaya:

- *Suttavibhaṅga*
- *Mahāvagga*
- *Cūlavagga*

Only the explanations of the meaning of the Dhamma as taught by the Buddha in this collection of Dhamma and Vinaya resources are trustworthy for leading to view straightening. Note that for both the *Dhammapāda* and the *Jātaka* collections, only the verses are trustworthy. Any other interpretations such as those of the *Abhidhamma Pitaka*, the Theravada commentaries, the Mahayana or any other interpretations that cannot be found in the Suttas or the Vinaya listed above should be discarded as instructed by the Buddha in the *mahāpadesa sutta* (AN 4.180):

“O bhikkhus, I will teach you these four great references. Listen to that and do mind it well, I will speak.”

“Yes Bhante,” those bhikkhus replied to the Auspicious One. The Auspicious One said this:

“And what, O bhikkhus, are the four great references? “Here, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu might say thus: “O friends, in the presence of the Auspicious One, this was heard by me, this was received in his presence. This is the Dhamma, this is the Vinaya, this is the Teacher’s instructions.” For him, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu’s words should simply not be delighted in, should not be rejected. Not having delighted in, not having rejected, having thoroughly learned his words and phrases, those [words and phrases] should be descended into the Suttas, pointed out in the Vinaya. If those are being made to fit in with the Suttas, those are being pointed out in the Vinaya, but cannot even descend into the Suttas, cannot be pointed out in the Vinaya, then you must reach this conclusion here: Certainly, this is simply not the words of the Auspicious One, the *arahant*, the rightly self-awakened one. This bhikkhu has learned them incorrectly. Thus, O bhikkhus, this must be discarded by you.

Or else here, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu might say thus: “O friends, in the presence of the Auspicious One, this was heard by me, this was received in his presence. This is the Dhamma, this is the Vinaya, this is the Teacher’s instructions.” For him, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu’s words should simply not be delighted in, should not be rejected. Not having delighted in, not having rejected, having thoroughly learned his words and phrases, those [words and phrases] should be descended into the Suttas, pointed out in the Vinaya. If those are being made to fit in with the Suttas, those are being pointed out in the Vinaya, and can just descend into the Suttas, can be pointed out in the Vinaya, then you must reach this conclusion here: Certainly, this is just the words of the Auspicious One, the *arahant*, the rightly self-awakened one. This bhikkhu has learned them correctly. This, O bhikkhus, is the first great reference that you should bear in mind.

Or else here, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu might say thus: Indeed in such and such dwelling place, a sangha dwells with an eminent elder... Indeed in such and such dwelling place, many elder bhikkhus dwell, who are well-learned, experts

on the discourses, bearers of the Dhamma, bearers of the Vinaya, bearers of the outlines... “Indeed in such and such dwelling place, one elder bhikkhu dwells, who is well-learned, expert on the discourses, bearer of the Dhamma, bearer of the Vinaya, bearer of the outlines. In the presence of that elder, this was heard by me, this was received in his presence. This is the Dhamma, this is the Vinaya, this is the Teacher’s instructions.” For him, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu’s words should simply not be delighted in, should not be rejected. Not having delighted in, not having rejected, having thoroughly learned his words and phrases, those [words and phrases] should be descended into the Suttas, pointed out in the Vinaya. If those are being made to fit in with the Suttas, those are being pointed out in the Vinaya, but cannot even descend into the Suttas, cannot be pointed out in the Vinaya, then you must reach this conclusion here: Certainly, this is simply not the words of the Auspicious One, the *arahant*, the rightly self-awakened one. This bhikkhu has learned them incorrectly. Thus, O bhikkhus, this must be discarded by you.

Or else here, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu might say thus: Indeed in such and such dwelling place, a sangha dwells with an eminent elder... Indeed in such and such dwelling place, many elder bhikkhus dwell, who are well-learned, experts on the discourses, bearers of the Dhamma, bearers of the Vinaya, bearers of the outlines... “Indeed in such and such dwelling place, one elder bhikkhu dwells, who is well-learned, expert on the discourses, bearer of the Dhamma, bearer of the Vinaya, bearer of the outlines. In the presence of that elder, this was heard by me, this was received in his presence. This is the Dhamma, this is the Vinaya, this is the Teacher’s instructions.” For him, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu’s words should simply not be delighted in, should not be rejected. Not having delighted in, not having rejected, having thoroughly learned his words and phrases, those [words and phrases] should be descended into the Suttas, pointed out in the Vinaya. If those are being made to fit in with the Suttas, those are being pointed out in the Vinaya, and can just descend into the Suttas, can be pointed out in the Vinaya, then you must reach this conclusion here: Certainly, this is simply the words of the Auspicious One, the *arahant*, the rightly self-awakened one. This bhikkhu

has learned them correctly. This, O bhikkhus, is the fourth great reference that you should bear in mind.

These, O bhikkhus, are the four great references.”

—AN 4.180

Here the Buddha is instructing us that regardless of what one claims to be the source of their interpretations of the Buddha’s teachings, whether they claim to have heard it from the Buddha himself, a Sangha, learned elders or elder, a sayadaw, a mahathera, an ajahn, a lay meditation master, whatever the source or authority may be, if their words and phrases are not in agreement with the Suttas or the Vinaya as recorded by the First Council, then one can safely reach the conclusion that whoever is making such a claim has simply not learned the Buddha’s teachings correctly and so whatever that person claims should be discarded, if one wants to interpret the Buddha’s teachings correctly.

In the *vimuttāyatana sutta* (AN 5.26), the Buddha gives the five domains of liberation as follows:

“There are, O bhikkhus, these five domains of liberation whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained unsurpassed security from bondage.” Which five?

“Here, O bhikkhus, the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma to a bhikkhu. In whichever way, O bhikkhus, the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma to that bhikkhu, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma. For one who experiences the meaning, experiences the Dhamma, joy is born. For the joyful, happiness is born. For one of a happy mind, the body becomes tranquil. One whose body is tranquil feels pleasure. The mind of one in pleasure attains samadhi. This, O bhikkhus, is the first domain of liberation, whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted

asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained unsurpassed security from bondage.”

“Furthermore, O bhikkhus, indeed not even the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma to the bhikkhu. Rather, he teaches the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it. In whichever way, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu teaches the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma. For one who experiences the meaning, experiences the Dhamma, joy is born. For the joyful, happiness is born. For one of a happy mind, the body becomes tranquil. One whose body is tranquil feels pleasure. The mind of one in pleasure attains samadhi. This, O bhikkhus, is the second domain of liberation, whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained unsurpassed security from bondage.”

“Furthermore, O bhikkhus, indeed not even the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma to the bhikkhu; nor does he teach the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it. Rather, he recites the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it. In whichever way, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu recites the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma. For one who experiences the meaning, experiences the Dhamma, joy is born. For the joyful, happiness is born. For one of a happy mind, the body becomes tranquil. One whose body is tranquil feels pleasure. The mind of one in pleasure attains samadhi. This, O bhikkhus, is the third domain of liberation, whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained unsurpassed security from bondage.”

“Furthermore, O bhikkhus, indeed not even the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma to the bhikkhu; nor does he

teach the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it; nor does he recite the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it. Rather, he deliberately thinks, ponders and mentally examines the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it. In whichever way, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu deliberately thinks, ponders and mentally examines the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma. For one who experiences the meaning, experiences the Dhamma, joy is born. For the joyful, happiness is born. For one of a happy mind, the body becomes tranquil. One whose body is tranquil feels pleasure. The mind of one in pleasure attains samadhi. This, O bhikkhus, is the fourth domain of liberation, whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained unsurpassed security from bondage.”

“Furthermore, O bhikkhus, indeed not even the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma to the bhikkhu; nor does he teach the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it; nor does he recite the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it; nor does he deliberately think, ponder and mentally examine the Dhamma in detail as he has heard it, as he has learned it. Rather, he has a certain sign of samadhi well grasped, well attended to, well retained in mind, well penetrated with wisdom. In whichever way, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu has a certain sign of samadhi well grasped, well attended to, well retained in mind, well penetrated with wisdom, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma. For one who experiences the meaning, experiences the Dhamma, joy is born. For the joyful, happiness is born. For one of a happy mind, the body becomes tranquil. One whose body is tranquil feels pleasure. The mind of one in pleasure attains samadhi. This, O bhikkhus, is the fifth domain of liberation, whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained

unsurpassed security from bondage.”

“These, O bhikkhus, are the five domains of liberation whereby for a bhikkhu dwelling ever vigilant, ardent and resolute, his unliberated mind becomes liberated, his unextincted asavas become utterly extincted, he attains the unattained unsurpassed security from bondage.”

–AN 5.26

When one is vigilant, ardent and resolute, relying only on these five domains of liberation to understand the meaning of the Buddha’s teachings, then one is said to be dwelling in the domain of liberation. Any irreversible liberation in the Buddha’s teachings such as stream entry, once-returner, non-returner and arahantship, or any meaningful progress like the purified virtue and the straightened view needed to become a faith follower or dhamma follower, does not happen outside of these five domains of liberation. That being so, here are a few important phrases worth highlighting in this *sutta* for those interested in making meaningful progress in the Buddha’s teaching.

First, the following phrase is worth highlighting:

yathā yathā bhikkhave tassa bhikkhuno satthā dhammaṃ deseti, aññataro vā garuṭṭhāniyo sabrahmacārī tathā tathā so tasmim dhamme atthapaṭisaṃvedī ca hoti, dhamma-paṭisaṃvedī ca.

In whatever way, O bhikkhus, the Teacher or a certain companion in the life of purity in the position of a teacher teaches the Dhamma for that bhikkhu, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma.

This means that in order to experience the meaning in the Dhamma being taught, one cannot look for the meaning from any other dhamma than the Dhamma taught by the Buddha or chief disciples that the Buddha placed in the position of a teacher, such as the venerable Sariputta and the venerable Mahamoggallana. In other words, one wishing to experience the meaning of the Dhamma as taught by the Buddha cannot rely on any other interpretations, but only rely on the interpretations as taught by the Buddha or others the Buddha placed in the position of a teacher.

The second phrase worth highlighting which is repeated several times in the Suttas is:

yathāsutaṃ yathāpariyattaṃ dhammaṃ vitthārena pare-
saṃ deseti... yathāsutaṃ yathāpariyattaṃ dhammaṃ vit-
thārena sajjhāyaṃ karoti... yathāsutaṃ yathāpariyattaṃ
dhammaṃ cetasā anuvitakketi anuvicāreti manasānupekkhati.

One teaches the Dhamma in detail as one has heard and as
one has learned it... One recites the Dhamma in detail as
one has heard and as one has learned it... One deliberately
think, ponder and mentally examine the Dhamma in detail
as one has heard and as one has learned it...

In some *vipassana* meditation and forest dhamma traditions, pari-
atti (learning) is often belittled as mere theory in favor of practicing
the techniques prescribed by their meditation masters. But here and
in many other Suttas, the Buddha stresses the importance of pariyatti
as the foundation for understanding his teachings. As stated in this
sutta, four of the five domains of liberation are based on pariyatti.
It is only by teaching the Dhamma in detail as one has heard it and
as one has learned it from the Buddha or someone the Buddha has
placed in the position of a teacher; or reciting the Dhamma in detail
as one has heard it and as one has learned it from the Buddha or
someone the Buddha has placed in the position of a teacher; or delib-
erately thinking, pondering and mentally examining the Dhamma in
detail as one has heard it and as one has learned it from the Buddha
or someone the Buddha has placed in the position of a teacher, that
one can succeed in experiencing the meaning of that Dhamma and
experiencing the Dhamma. If one interprets the Buddha's teachings
according to the explanation of the meaning from one's own tradition
like Theravada, Mahayana or Vajirayana interpretations, then one
cannot expect to experience the Dhamma as taught by the Buddha or
someone the Buddha has placed in the position of a teacher.

Lastly, the phrase:

yathā yathā bhikkhave bhikkhuno aññataraṃ samādhinimit-
taṃ suggahitaṃ hoti sumanasikataṃ sūpadhāritaṃ sup-
paṭividdhaṃ paññāya, tathā tathā so tasmim dhamme
atthapaṭisaṃvedī ca hoti dhammapaṭisaṃvedī ca.

In whatever way, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu has a certain sign of samadhi well grasped, well attended to, well retained in mind, well penetrated with wisdom, in just that way, he experiences the meaning in that Dhamma and experiences the Dhamma.

Here again, if the sign of *samādhi* one grasps or one's experience of *samādhi* cannot be found in the Suttas or pointed out in the Vinaya, then one can safely discard such a *samādhi* attainment as wrong *samādhi* (*miccā samādhi*) which will only lead to wrong liberation (*miccā vimutti*) if pursued. In the Suttas, the Buddha clearly defines what the *jhāna* of right *samādhi* (*sammā samādhi*) entail without any ambiguity, giving very detailed similes so that there can be no doubt as to whether the *jhāna* one has attained is wrong *samādhi* or right *samādhi*. For example in the *kāyagatāsati sutta* (MN 119), the Buddha describes how one develops mindfulness of the body in the first *jhāna* as follows:

Furthermore, O bhikkhus, quite secluded from sense-desires, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the happiness and pleasure born of seclusion, with thinking and with pondering, the first *jhāna*.

Just as, O bhikkhus, an expert bath attendant or bath attendant's apprentice, having splashed and sprinkled bath-soap powder with water would mix it. His ball of soap would be permeated with moisture, saturated with moisture, drenched with moisture inside and out but without dripping.

So too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with happiness and pleasure born of seclusion. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with happiness and pleasure born of seclusion. Of his dwelling thus vigilant, ardent and resolute, his memories and intentions connected with the home life gets abandoned. With their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in *samādhi*. Thus too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu develops mindfulness of the body.

—MN 119

Nowadays, many meditation masters cannot tell the difference between the *jhāna* of a self-hypnotic trance and the *jhāna* of right *samādhi*. They claim that if one can still experience feelings of pleasure in the body while in *jhāna* as described in the mindfulness of the body sutta, then one has not really attained *jhāna* since the mind is not yet fully absorbed in a meditation object. Of course the Buddha did not deny that such an attainment of *jhāna* where the mind is fixed on some object is possible, but he did not praise that kind of *jhāna*. He compared it to the *jhāna* of an untrained horse whose mind is fixed on fodder when tied to the feeding trough in the *sandha sutta* (AN 11.9) as follows:

Cultivate the *jhāna*, O Sandha, of a thoroughbred horse, not the *jhāna* of an untrained horse. And what is the *jhāna* of an untrained horse?

Indeed an untrained horse, O Sandha, when tied to a feeding trough, fixates: “O fodder, O fodder.” What is the reason for that? Because, O Sandha, when the untrained horse is tied to the feeding trough, it does not occur to it: “What tasks will my horse trainer give me today? How should I respond accordingly?” Being tied to the feeding trough, it just fixates: “O fodder, O fodder.”

So too, O Sandha, here a certain untrained person, gone to the forest, also gone to the root of a tree, also gone to an empty hut, dwells with his mind obsessed by sensual desire, overwhelmed by sensual desire. But he does not understand as it has come to be the escape from that arisen sensual desire. While harbouring sensual desire within, he fixates, in a daze, with a gaze, unfazed... With his mind obsessed by ill-will... obsessed by sluggishness and lack of mental agility... obsessed by restlessness and remorse... obsessed by doubt, overwhelmed by doubt. But he does not understand as it has come to be the escape from that arisen doubt. While harbouring doubt within, he fixates, in a daze, with a gaze, unfazed. He also fixates in dependence on earth; also fixates in dependence on water; also fixates in dependence on fire; also fixates in dependence on air; also fixates in dependence on the domain of infinite space; also fixates in dependence on the domain of infinite consciousness; also fixates in dependence on the domain of nothingness; also fixates in dependence on the domain of

neither perception nor non-perception; also fixates in dependence on this world; also fixates in dependence on the other world; whatever is seen, heard, thought, cognized, attained, sought after, pondered over by the mind, that also he fixates in dependence on. Thus, O Sandha, is how the untrained person cultivates *jhāna*.

–AN 11.9

Note that whatever object the untrained person depends on for his mental fixity, be it the four great elements or any form derived from the four great elements or the formless *āyatanas* is not the culprit for the Buddha's criticism of the untrained person's *jhāna*. The fault the Buddha finds with the untrained person's *jhāna* is that he does not understand the escape from the arisen hindrances (*nissaraṇaṃ yathābhūtaṃ nappajānāti*), since the untrained person does not possess the Dhamma-eye by which he can see the escape from the arisen hindrances where they cease without remainder. He says in the *mahāsalāyatanika sutta* (MN 149) that both *samatha* and *vipassana* have to be brought into being (*bhāvetabbā*) with supreme knowledge (*abhiññā*), which from the *mūlapariyāya sutta* (MN 1), is defined as a *sekha's* knowledge.

Thus, it is important to cross-check any *samādhi* attainment one experiences with the *samādhi* attainments as taught by the Buddha in the Suttas if one wants to experience the meaning of the Dhamma and consequently experience the Dhamma. If the type of *jhāna* one has attained does not allow one to feel the body as described in the *kāyagatāsati sutta* and yet is not a formless attainment, then one can reach the conclusion that it is not the *jhāna* of right *samādhi* and can only lead to wrong liberation, therefore one should discard it and not pursue it.

The Buddha guarantees in the *pāsādika sutta* (DN 29) that any one who sees his teachings sees it as complete and pure, without anything lacking or anything superfluous. Those who think anything can be added to improve the Buddha's teachings and make it more complete simply do not see the Dhamma. Similarly, those who think any thing should be taken away to make it more pure also simply do not see the Dhamma.

“And what is it that seeing, one does not see?” Indeed, this

is truly what he sees: “A life of purity that is successful in all aspects, complete in all aspects, with nothing lacking and nothing superfluous, well-proclaimed in its completeness and purity.” If he were to deduct anything from it, thinking: “In this way it will be purer”, then he does not see it. And if he were to add anything to it, thinking: “In this way it will be more complete”, then he does not see it. This is [the proper meaning of] “seeing, he does not see.”
–DN 29

One should keep in mind that the Buddha’s initial hesitation to teach this Dhamma was simply because the breakthrough to the Dhamma is required to understand his teachings, and making the breakthrough to the Dhamma is very difficult as stated in the *āyācana sutta* (SN 6.1):

Then when the Auspicious One had gone to a lonely place and was in seclusion, the following reflection arose in his mind thus: “This Dhamma that I have attained is deep, difficult to see, difficult to awaken to, peaceful, excellent, not within the sphere of reasoning, subtle, to be personally experienced by the wise. But this generation delights in attachment, enjoys attachment, rejoices in attachment. For a generation delighting in attachment, enjoying attachment, rejoicing in attachment, this principle is difficult to see, namely, this conditionality, dependent origination. This principle too is difficult to see, namely, the stilling of all sankharas, the relinquishment of all ownership, the extinction of thirsting, fading away, cessation, nibbana. But if I were to teach the Dhamma and others just could not understand me, that would be troublesome for me, that would be wearisome for me.”
–SN 6.1

Making the breakthrough to the four noble truths to understand the Buddha’s teachings is the most difficult accomplishment ever that can be attained by one throughout this beginning-less *samsāra*. Therefore one should not be too quick to look for interpretations of the meaning outside of the five domains of liberation, which are the study and practice in dependence on the Suttas and the Vinaya. No shortcuts

exist outside of the Suttas and Vinaya. Thus, it is better for one to know that one has not understood the Dhamma and persist patiently, dwelling within the five domains of liberation until one's view become straight enough to experience the meaning of the Dhamma and arrive at true understanding, than to look elsewhere for interpretations that misleads one to think one has understood that which one has not understood. As the Buddha advises in the dhammapada verse 63.

yo bālo maññati bālyam,
paṇḍito vāpi tena so;
Bālo ca paṇḍitamānī,
sa ve "bālo"ti vuccati.

The fool who conceives his foolishness,
by that extent he is wise;
but the fool who conceives himself to be wise,
is said to be truly a fool indeed.
–Dhp 63

Thus, it is only with vigilance, patience and persistence, dwelling in the five domains of liberation, relying only on the Suttas and the Vinaya resources as listed above, that one can succeed at the view straightening needed to fulfill the very starting point of wholesome dhammas. If one succeeds at this, then one has purified one's virtue and one has straightened one's view to be in conformity with the virtue and view of the noble ones.

With virtue that is purified and view that has become straight as foundation, if based on one's faith in the Buddha's awakening and one's faith in the Buddha's teachings on impermanence, one is resolved on realizing the Buddha's teachings on impermanence to the extent that the five faculties have come to be (see *kīṭāgiri sutta* MN 70), the Buddha declares of such a one in the *khandhā sutta* (SN 25.10):

"This is called a faith follower (*saddhānusārī*), one who has entered upon the fixed course of rightness, who has entered the plane of the true man, who has transcended the plane of the *puthujjana*. He is unable to do that deed which having done such a deed, he would be reborn in hell,

or the animal womb or the sphere of ghost. He is definitely incapable of passing away as long as he has not realized the fruit of stream entry.”

–SN 25.10

With virtue that is purified and view that has become straight as foundation, if one submits to the Buddha’s teachings on impermanence based on a measure of understanding with wisdom, and one is resolved on realizing these teachings to the extent that the five faculties have come to be (see *kiṭṭāgiri sutta* MN 70), the Buddha declares of such a one in the *khandhā sutta* (SN 25.10):

“This is called a dhamma follower (*dhammānusārī*), one who has entered upon the fixed course of rightness, who has entered the plane of the true man, who has transcended the plane of the *puthujjana*. He is unable to do that deed which having done such a deed, he would be reborn in hell, or the animal womb, or the sphere of ghost. He is definitely incapable of passing away as long as he has not realized the fruit of stream entry.”

–SN 25.10

Both the *saddhānusārī* and *dhammānusārī* have entered upon the path to the realization of the fruit of stream-entry. By relying on the five faculties they have acquired, if they strive for the breakthrough to the four noble truths with vigilance and acquire the Dhamma-eye that knows and sees the Buddha’s teachings on impermanence, the Buddha declares of such a one in the *khandhā sutta* (SN 25.10):

“This is called a stream enterer (*sotāpanna*), not subject to the woeful plane, on a fixed course, destined for supreme awakening.”

–SN 25.10

This is the unsurpassed surgery, the method of the Buddhas that awakens the Dhamma-eye, by which one sees the impermanence which leads to purification as taught by the Buddha, the unsurpassed surgeon.